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SOURCES OF EMISSION

TRAVEL AND TRANSPORTATION

INFRASTRUCTURE AND VENUE CONSTRUCTION

ENERGY USAGE

WASTE GENERATION

WATER USAGE

FOOD AND BEVERAGE SERVICES

SPECTATOR ACCOMMODATION

PROMOTIONAL MATERIALS

SOURCE DALBERG ADVISORS

WITH THE SHOWPIECE ICC Men's Cricket World Cup well underway, the tension and anticipation are palpable in the air, and with good reason. In 2011, the last time India hosted the Cup, it lifted the trophy. Indeed, since then, the two subsequent hosts—Australia in 2015 and England in 2019—won the Cup, further boosting the host's hopes.

That optimism has also been fuelled by the Indian team's formidable line-up, featuring the likes of Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Hardik Pandya, Ravindra Jadeja, Mohammed Shami and Jasprit Bumrah.

And India is expected to host over 2.48 million visitors wishing to watch the 48 matches involving 10 countries that will be played in stadiums across 10 cities over 46 days between October 5 and November 19. With such numbers, the tournament is seen boosting the economy and the fortunes of India's cricketing administrator, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI).

But amid this excitement, there is one aspect that will need to be reckoned with—the Cup's carbon footprint. Although projected carbon emission figures for the event haven't been officially calculated, industry experts estimate that it could rival the emissions seen at the FIFA World Cup Qatar 2022, estimated at around 3.6 million tonnes of carbon dioxide (CO₂) emissions, or the equivalent of 1.34 billion litres of diesel, based on the US Environmental Protection Agency's calculator. But, no measures to offset such emissions have been announced.

"The cricket World Cup will not be anything less unless sustainable measures are taken," says Ajay Pillai, Partner for Risk Advisory at Deloitte India. He explains that though there are fewer matches in this tournament than in the football event,

the duration of a 50-over cricket match is longer. Most are day-night matches, requiring floodlights, extensive travel for the teams, and a large number of spectators.

TRICKY CALCULATIONS

The first big hurdle in addressing this challenge is calculating the carbon footprint. The multifaceted nature of carbon emissions—from diverse sources to the availability of data, temporal considerations, indirect emissions, and behavioural influences, to name just a few factors—adds to the complexity.

Every event has a unique carbon footprint that depends on multiple factors, such as the materials used in construction or renovation, the energy consumed for lighting and air conditioning, transportation, and so on. "It is crucial to note that the precise carbon footprint estimates for a particular event can vary greatly depending on the host country's infrastructure, transportation systems, and energy sources," explains Jagjeet Sareen, climate expert at management consulting firm Dalberg Advisors.

Such an analysis has been done in India. Last year, Schneider Electric and Indian Premier League (IPL) franchise Rajasthan Royals calculated the carbon footprint of one T20 match at about 10,000 tonnes of CO₂ equivalent—or about 3.72 million litres of diesel—and this was when the tournament was played in only two cities due to Covid-19 and had a low carbon footprint.

This helped Rajasthan Royals and Schneider Electric host a carbon-neutral match, where an emission offset strategy was adopted. Under this, Schneider Electric committed to working with other agencies to plant 17,000 trees over six months to sequester CO₂ emissions over